

ES 212 / UC 214 – Entrepreneurial Business Basics

Fall 2025

Course Overview

This course introduces you to business basics that are useful in entrepreneurial businesses and across business stages. We will introduce foundational business concepts and consider how entrepreneurial ventures create value.

We will consider what makes for a good entrepreneurial idea, how entrepreneurial ventures work, and how entrepreneurial companies turn ideas into products and services. Students will evaluate opportunities and challenges in entrepreneurial businesses, understand ways to mitigate risks, and develop a foundation to further understand entrepreneurship and business for your time at U of M and in your career.

This course helps undergraduate students from many disciplines learn entrepreneurial business basics.

Students bring a variety of backgrounds and have differing levels of business experience and knowledge. Our different backgrounds enrich the discussion. The course works best if all students thoroughly prepare to discuss the topics and bring their particular knowledge and questions to the subject.

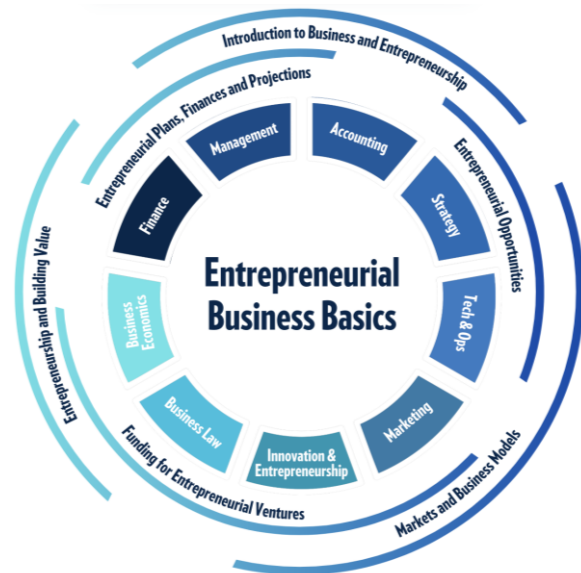
Learning objectives

This course introduces you to fundamental concepts in business and entrepreneurship and essential skill development for entrepreneurs including innovation / creativity, analytical and integrative thinking, decision-making under uncertainty, project management and working on diverse teams, and communicating effectively.

Our specific course learning objectives are outlined below:

Knowledge

- Foundational business areas, concepts, and terminology
- What entrepreneurship is and why it matters to society
- Key challenges faced by entrepreneurs
- How to understand customer needs
- How entrepreneurs create value for customers and users
- Different types of business models
- Product design and development
- Markets and market research
- Introductory economic ideas
- Introductory accounting concepts and startup financials
- Company formation and team-building



- Startup financing and investor perspective
- Startup presentations and plans

Skills

- Develop hypotheses on entrepreneurial value creation
- Gather relevant, important information and effectively synthesize findings from research and data
- Communicate clearly and effectively through presentations and written deliverables
- Develop project management and team skills
- Develop business viability analysis skills
- Formulate an innovation strategy and apply design skills through action-based learning

Office hours

I will have office hours via Zoom as posted on Canvas. **Please schedule appointments in advance via the online scheduling system or email.** I am happy to schedule times outside of normal office hours if you have a scheduling conflict.

Student Wellness

Review the Student Wellness section on Canvas.

Academic Integrity

Review the Academic Integrity section on Canvas.

Accommodations

Review the Accommodations section on Canvas.

Prerequisites

There are no prerequisites for this course. You must be enrolled and in good standing as an undergraduate student at the University of Michigan and not be pursuing a BBA or other program at the Ross School of Business. Ross has an extensive selection of entrepreneurship courses for business students.

The course is taken for credit. It cannot be audited.

Course materials

Background readings and cases are in the course pack that you will need to purchase and are available on Canvas. We will use other materials drawn from a variety of sources that will be posted on Canvas. Instructions to access the course pack are on Canvas.

All materials generated for the course including slides, handouts, review materials and assignments, or any other materials prepared by you or the professor for this course, are intended for use by current students in this class only, unless you have the permission of your instructor. You are not permitted to use materials related to the class that were generated by the professor or students in previous versions of this course. A violation of this policy may be a violation of the Ross Community Values Code and may result in disciplinary action.

Course website: CANVAS

You are responsible for checking your email daily and/or Canvas course site for course updates sent as announcement from Canvas.

Ross School of Business Statement on Attendance and Contribution

Below is a Ross School of Business statement on class contribution that captures an essential element of this course. The contribution of all students is vital to making this a successful class for everyone.

“The Ross learning experience transforms students by developing the ability to think rigorously, work collaboratively, and lead effectively. The classroom and course work are foundational components of the Ross learning and growth process. Classroom activities are central to each student’s experience – an experience they share with their classmates and faculty to develop each student’s knowledge and personal growth and that of the student body as a whole.

Due to the importance of this shared experience, students should attend all classes, arrive on time, stay in class throughout and be prepared to contribute to the learning process for all. The expected level of engagement goes far beyond mere presence in class. Rather, students come to each class having read all materials, prepared all assignments, and be ready to share their insights, thoughts and intellectual struggles with their classmates. Students should remain engaged and attentive throughout class, both for their own learning and in respect to the rest of the Ross community. Violations of these expectations will be reflected by reductions of the class participation grade as well as other penalties faculty may view as appropriate.”

Use of Generative AI

Generative artificial intelligence (AI) technologies like ChatGPT can be great research and creativity tools. In this class, you are permitted and encouraged to use these tools to research markets and companies, facilitate your work in generating and iterating on your ideas, help evaluate your hypotheses, and potentially to help generate images or graphs useful to presentations for your venture (with appropriate citations). You should NOT use these tools as a substitute for your own thinking or writing on assignments, class surveys on Canvas, or group work. This is an action-based course where we learn by doing. Completing assignments and surveys including writing memos and developing presentations is an essential part of learning in the course and a powerful mechanism for thinking clearly about entrepreneurial opportunity and risk. As such, you should NOT use AI technologies to complete your writing, presentations, or group work. You may find these tools helpful for outlining.

Be aware that current AI tools may offer incomplete or incorrect information. Make sure to cite the use of AI tools as you would other resources. We will talk about AI more during class and the field is moving fast – let me know on any questions you have.

(thanks to the Temple University Center for the Advancement of Teaching for syllabus suggestions that informed this policy)

Grading

Grades will be assigned in accordance with the Ross School of Business grading policy, following the grade distribution guidelines.

Attendance is mandatory. Arriving late, leaving early, or being absent will affect your contribution grade. You are allowed **two absences**. **Please check in with me at the time regarding reasons for a missed class or needing to adjust assignment deadlines.**

Grading percentages:

Class contribution (individual)	10%
Quizzes (individual)	30%
Final exam (individual)	20%
Startup Needs assignment (individual)	10%
Venture presentation and risks / venture viability memo (group)	30%

Your grade across all areas will include assessment of the quality of the content and the clarity and conciseness of your oral and written expression.

Contribution

Class contribution is important because it enhances everyone's active learning experience. The quantity and quality of contribution in class matter. You should come to class prepared for a discussion, with the materials read and carefully considered. Focus on contributions that advance the discussion and your classmates' understanding of the topic or that raise interesting questions during class. You will also have the opportunity to contribute via modules / questions on Canvas. You may also suggest discussion points or follow-up articles to me via email. You should contribute throughout the class and not simply in the final weeks. I will also ask for group contribution feedback regarding the team project.

Quizzes and Final Exam

Quizzes may cover material from the week that they are given and material from prior class sessions and readings. Quizzes will be taken on Canvas and cannot be made up unless under extraordinary circumstances.

You will have a total of 7 quizzes. The lowest of the 7 quiz scores will be dropped automatically. The 6 highest quiz scores together represent 30% of your grade.

The final exam is taken in-person and will cover class sessions, discussions, and assigned materials from throughout the semester and represents 20% of your grade.

Project

For the project, you will work to develop a proposal for a new venture working as individuals and as an entrepreneurial team. The project includes a startup needs assignment (individual), hypothesis on startup value creation (individual), business model drafting (team), in-class elevator pitch (team), and an in-class final presentation (with slide deck) and memo on risks / mitigation strategies / venture viability (team). **The startup needs assignment (individual) and final presentation (including slide deck) and memo (team) are the graded deliverables.**

All assignments must be turned in by uploading the document to Canvas before the specified deadline.

Late Submissions

You may be eligible for:

- 95% of the total score if the assignment is turned in within one (1) hour of the deadline
- 80% of the total score if the assignment is turned in within one (1) day of the deadline

Submissions more than a day late will not be accepted.

Course Modules and Topics

The following is an overview of the course modules and topics. The agenda is flexible and may be modified before or during the course. We may make some adjustments based on our discussions or interesting topics that come up.

Topics
Introduction to business, entrepreneurship, and this course Topics: Foundational business concepts and terminology What is entrepreneurship? What are different types of entrepreneurship? What is this course about? Key tasks and challenges in entrepreneurship Materials: Syllabus
Entrepreneurship and creating value Topics: Thinking about entrepreneurial problems and customer needs What is a value proposition?
Trends, technology, and thinking about the future Topics: Trends analysis and technology forecasting How do you think about entrepreneurial opportunities in these trends? Materials: “How Computers Changed Everything”, Johnson
Intro to business models Topics: What is a business model? Overview of different business model concepts How is a business model developed and used? Materials: “Business Model Analysis for Entrepreneurs”, Eisenmann
Entrepreneurial opportunities and business models Topics: What makes an entrepreneurial opportunity worth pursuing? Intro to presentations and plans Materials: “Hypothesis-Driven Entrepreneurship”, Eisenmann, Ries, Dillard
Entrepreneurship and society Topics: How social entrepreneurship ventures create value Thinking about needs, opportunities, and measuring impact Materials: University of Michigan Social Venture Fund on Triple Bottom Line

Basic economic ideas for startups

Topics: Markets and pricing
Supply and demand
Pricing and elasticity, substitutes and complements

Materials: “Marketing Analysis Toolkit: Pricing and Profitability Analysis”, Steenburgh, Avery

Design and production of products and services

Topics: What is customer discovery?
Product design, product development phases
Customer feedback, iterative process

Materials: “Customer Movie Experience” exercise

Market entry planning, marketing, and selling, product / market fit

Topics: Describing and sizing a market, market research techniques
Promotion and selling in a startup
Product / market fit and startup metrics
Risks and mitigation

Materials: “Food Truck Challenge”, Roberto
“How Superhuman Built an Engine to Find Product / Market Fit”, Vohra, firstround.com

Forming a company

Topics: Choosing a business structure
Introduction to business contracts and intellectual property (IP)
Regulatory context for entrepreneurial ventures

Entrepreneurial teams

Topics: Building an entrepreneurial team
Establishing roles and founder shares in the company

Materials: “Lean in Stories: Heather Hiles”, Hiles, leanin.org
“The Management Team: While Building Usage” Wilson, avc.com

Startup projections and financials

Topics: Assumptions for financial projections
Intro to financial statements (income statement, balance sheet, cash flow statement)

Value-creating milestones
Materials: Notes on Projections and Milestones, Johnson
Funding for Startups
Topics: Overview of funding sources What do investors look for? Plans and presentations
Materials: “Financing New Ventures”, Kerr, Nanda
Fitting it all together
Topics: What did you learn? How will you take this forward?